Initially, the Mappilas had considerable success. In August 1921 the police attempted to arrest a number of Khilafat members gathered in the Mambaram mosque in Tirurangadi, among them the imam, Haji Ali Musliyar (see illustration), whose family had played a leading role in several earlier Mappila uprisings in which his grandfather and an elder brother had been killed. A large crowd of Mappilas prevented the police from making any arrests, but the police station itself was then attacked, leading the police to open fire. A Mappila uprising followed, which over the next few weeks spread to more than half a dozen districts. Police stations were seized, government buildings occupied, and in the districts of Ernad and Valluvanad a Muslim state was declared. In August 1921 Haji Varian Kunnath Kunjahamma, of whom very little seems to be known, took over the rebellion's leadership from Ali Musliyar and issued a promulgation that no harm should come to any non-Muslims and that there should be no looting – orders that often went unheeded. By the time law and order had been restored by heavy-handed military intervention some six hundred Hindu and Christian civilians had been murdered and somewhere between 2337 (the official figure) and 10,000 (the unofficial estimate) Mappila rebels killed, at a cost of forty-three troops dead.

The government was in no mood to show mercy. Haji Varian Kunnath Kunjahamma was among an unknown number of prisoners who were tried by a military tribunal and shot by firing squad in the Kottakumo fort in Malappuram. Haji Ali Musliyar was one of a dozen leaders who were sentenced to death and hanged. At least twenty thousand Mappilas were deported to the penal colony in the Andaman Islands. A regime normally so scrupulous in keeping records and statistics signally failed to produce reliable figures of the human cost of the Mappila revolt, giving rise to wild exaggerations on both sides. A conference summoned by the Zamorin of Calicut